

RESEARCH ARTICLE

A PRISMA-Based Systematic Review on Economic, Social, and Governance Practices: Insights and Research Agenda

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Received: 27 March 2024 | **Revised:** 3 November 2024 | **Accepted:** 10 November 2024

Keywords: ESG | integrative framework | non-financial firms | PRISMA | sustainability reporting | systematic literature review

ABSTRACT

The article synthesizes existing research on environmental, social, and governance (ESG) practices and explores their impact on corporate sustainability and financial outcomes. [Correction added on 17 December 2024, after first online publication: In the Abstract section, the definition of ESG has been corrected from ‘economic, social, and governance’ to ‘environmental, social, and governance’.] A systematic literature review (SLR) followed PRISMA guidelines, analyzing 85 peer-reviewed articles from high-quality journals indexed in Scopus. The results reveal that robust governance mechanisms—such as board diversity, strategic integration of ESG criteria, and effective risk management—are key drivers of enhanced ESG performance and corporate profitability. However, the findings also highlight significant gaps in current knowledge, particularly regarding emerging concepts like green innovation, ESG controversies, and digital transformation. The study concludes that further research is needed to develop a more nuanced understanding of how different governance structures and ESG practices interact and to provide clearer guidance for policymakers and corporate managers in fostering sustainable business practices.

JEL Classification: G30, G34, G20, Q56, P27, Q01

1 | Introduction

In today's ecosystem, the shift toward responsible investment frameworks is crucial. Integrating economic growth with societal and environmental well-being addresses global sustainability challenges (Pompella and Costantino 2023). ESG criteria have become essential non-financial indicators for investors, customers, and regulators, reflecting firms' operational climates (Howard-Grenville 2021). ESG performance positively impacts valuations in both developed and emerging markets (Ting et al. 2019), mitigates risk (Zhang et al. 2023), and alleviates financing constraints (Hou 2023). Corporate governance, especially through the board of directors, plays a key role in promoting corporate social responsibility (Frias-Aceituno et al., 2013). Balancing governance and profitability are therefore critical for

investment decisions (Rao et al. 2023), with increased investor attention on boards (Rossi et al. 2021).

While existing reviews synthesize studies on ESG (see Table 1), many do not account for industry specifics, recent developments or either do not properly apply the protocol for selecting the sample to be examined. Particularly, despite growing recognition of ESG's role in corporate governance and sustainability, especially within non-financial firms, the literature remains fragmented, lacking a comprehensive view. Many studies focus on isolated ESG aspects without integrating findings across the non-financial sector (i.e., Atz et al. 2023; Khaw, Amran, and Teoh 2024; Zeng et al. 2024), highlighting the need for a systematic approach to capture the breadth of ESG research in these industries. Our study

The authors reported that the work is original and had not been published earlier. All authors read and approved the final manuscript.

TABLE 1 | Recent systematic reviews on ESG.

Article	Authors (year)	Focus of review
Does Sustainability Generate Better Financial Performance? Review, Meta-Analysis, and Propositions	Atz et al. (2023)	Financial performance of ESG investing
The Impact of Social Responsibility on Corporate Financial Performance: A Systematic Literature Review	Coelho, Jayantilal, and Ferreira (2023)	Firm's financial performance and CSR activities, without a detailed analysis of the mechanisms through which CSR impacts financial performance
Global Drivers for ESG Performance: The Body of Knowledge	Daugaard and Ding (2022)	Economic drivers, regulatory impact, and socially responsible investing
Environmental, Social and Governance (ESG) Activity and Firm Performance: A Review and Consolidation	Huang (2021)	Environmental, social, and governance (ESG) factors and company's performance through the review of only 21 prior studies
ESG Disclosure and Firm Performance: A Bibliometric and Meta-Analysis	M.A. Khan (2022)	ESG disclosure and firm performance
Factors Influencing ESG Performance: A Bibliometric Analysis, Systematic Literature Review, and Future Research Directions	Khaw, Amran, and Teoh (2024)	Factors influencing ESG performance
The Use of ESG Scores in Academic Literature: A Systematic Literature Review	Clément, Robinot, and Trespeuch (2023)	Sustainability, CSR, disclosure, finance, and ESG scores through the review of papers containing only the keywords "ESG score(s)"
ESG and Financial Variables: A Systematic Review	M. Saini et al. (2023)	The relationship between corporate social performance and financial performance, through reviewing papers selected only based on abstract reading

Note: This table lists prior reviews on ESG performance and disclosure.
Source: Authors' elaboration.

fills these gaps by systematically reviewing ESG performance and disclosure literature, providing a comprehensive framework of antecedents, mediators, moderators, and outcomes in non-financial industries. The focus on non-financial sectors reflects our concern as these are typically the sectors with operational activities that may have a direct impact on the ESG pillars, making their practices and performance particularly critical. It is therefore essential to provide valuable information to the managers of non-financial companies, as they are the ones most in need of improving their ESG ranking.

This research aims to map the landscape of ESG performance and disclosure, identifying gaps and opportunities for future exploration. It provides a comprehensive view of ESG integration and effectiveness in non-financial industries across developed and emerging markets. The key research questions addressed are as follows: (1) Which journals, countries, and theories dominate ESG literature in non-financial firms? (2) What are the dominant themes in ESG literature? (3) What are the future research directions?

To answer these, we conducted a systematic literature review (SLR) following methodologies used in previous studies on sustainability and ESG (Fatima and Elbanna 2023; Palau-Pinyana, Llach, and Bagur-Femenias 2023; Velte 2023; Widyawati 2020). PRISMA guidelines (Page et al. 2021) were applied to

ensure transparency and objectivity (Z. Rehman, Baharun, and Salleh 2020). We analyzed 85 empirical papers up to 2023 from Scopus-listed, high-quality journals.

This paper offers a preliminary effort to systematically review ESG literature, building an integrated framework of antecedents, mediators, moderators, and outcomes of ESG performance and disclosure. The study has several managerial implications: Managers should incorporate ESG into governance frameworks for sustainability (Aouadi and Marsat 2018), ensure board diversity for effective governance (Nirino et al. 2021), incentivize ESG performance through compensation (Al Farooque, Buachoom, and Hoang 2019), and integrate ESG risk into broader risk management (He et al. 2023).

The structure of the paper is as follows: Section 2 discusses the theoretical background. Section 3 discusses research methodology. Section 4 presents descriptive analysis and results. Section 5 is the conclusions.

2 | Theoretical Background

ESG factors have become crucial indicators of a firm's sustainability and ethical impact in management and corporate governance. ESG encompasses three pillars that assess a firm's

social environmental and governance responsibilities. Financial firms, such as banks and asset managers, operate in highly regulated environments focused on stability and risk management, with revenues dependent on interest, fees, and trading activities (Laeven and Levine 2009). Their governance structures prioritize mitigating systemic risks and adhering to strict regulations (Barth, Caprio, and Levine 2013). In contrast, non-financial firms, spanning industries like manufacturing and technology, generate revenue through goods or services, making them more vulnerable to consumer demand, competition, and industry-specific environmental and social regulations (Porter and Kramer 2006). This distinction highlights how financial and non-financial firms' approach ESG practices differently.

Regarding ESG disclosure, financial firms focus on regulatory compliance and climate-related financial risks, often using the TCFD framework to address how ESG factors impact financial stability and investment portfolios (M. Khan, Serafeim, and Yoon 2016; Laeven and Levine 2009). Non-financial firms, spanning diverse industries, have broader ESG disclosures due to direct environmental impacts. They report on issues like carbon emissions, resource management, labor practices, and community relations, often through GRI and SASB frameworks, to meet diverse stakeholder expectations (Clark, Feiner, and Viehs 2015). These disclosures emphasize both environmental and social governance, fostering long-term sustainability and stakeholder trust (Kolk 2008).

3 | Research Methodology

We conducted a SLR following prior research (Fatima and Elbanna 2023; Palau-Pinyana, Llach, and Bagur-Femenías 2023; Velte 2023; Widyawati 2020). SLR serves as a key foundation for research (Snyder 2019) by providing a comprehensive synthesis of existing knowledge (Page et al. 2021), offering higher quality,

more transparent analyses (Siddaway, Wood, and Hedges 2019), and identifying research gaps for future exploration (Ed-Dafali, Patel, and Iqbal 2023; Page et al. 2021). This method is especially useful in assessing the current ESG landscape in non-financial firms, illuminating gaps in the literature (Galletta et al. 2024).

To ensure proper selection of papers, we applied PRISMA guidelines, following established frameworks (Hollebeek et al. 2023; Bengtsson et al. 2024; Aburto Barrera and Wagner 2023; Shah et al. 2023). PRISMA ensures a transparent and objective SLR process (Z. Rehman, Baharun, and Salleh 2020; Page et al. 2021). Our process involved identifying, selecting, and including relevant studies (Page et al. 2021), using rigorous filters to guarantee temporal coverage and relevance to ESG in non-financial firms. Therefore, the sample was selected by specifically screening the relevant documents based on different phases as shown in Figure 1.

3.1 | Identification Phase

The initial step of the PRISMA protocol involves identifying data items, including the research question and relevant studies (Z. Rehman, Baharun, and Salleh 2020; Galletta et al. 2024). We began by selecting research from the Scopus database, known for its high-quality indexing and reliability in scientific journals (Kumar et al. 2022; Orduna-Malea et al. 2015). Scopus offers detailed, quantitative data and a comprehensive global overview of research output across disciplines (Kusnoto et al. 2024; Bornmann, Butz, and Wohlrabe 2018). It identifies more citations and titles than the Web of Science, producing more robust search results (Vieira and Gomes 2009; Levine-Clark and Gil 2021), especially in sustainability (Pasko et al. 2021).

We adopted strict inclusion and exclusion criteria for the research sample. The search covered all years up to December

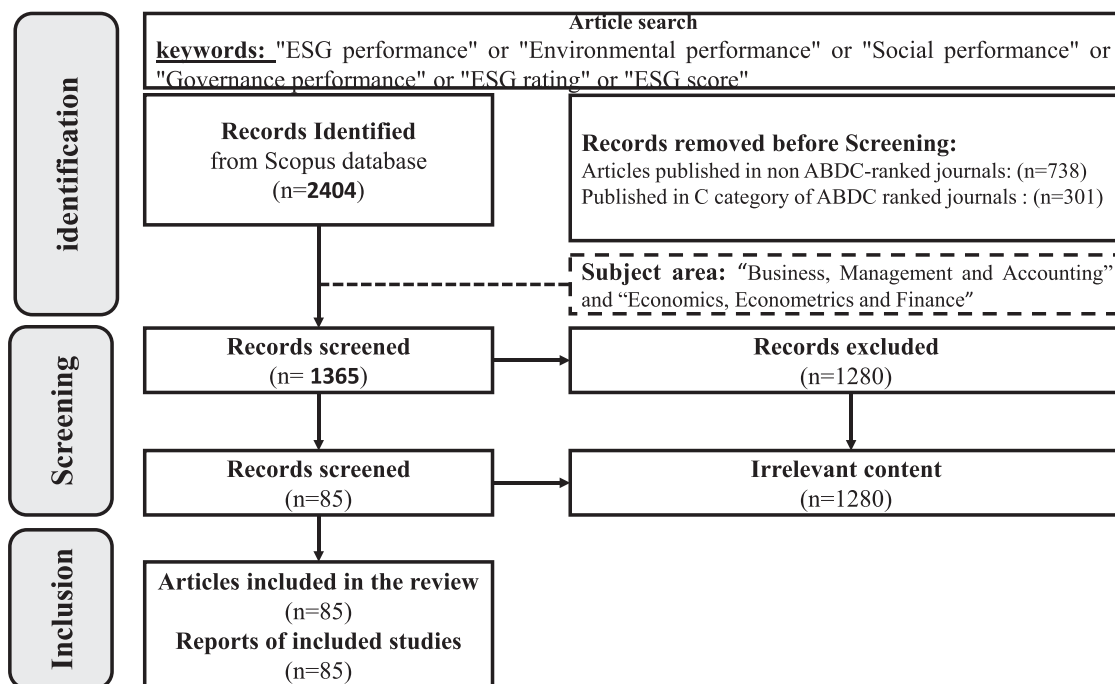


FIGURE 1 | Screening data process. **Source:** Authors' elaboration.

2023, targeting articles with keywords like “ESG Performance” or “Governance Performance,” while excluding those related to financial industries (e.g., “bank,” “financial sectors”). Only peer-reviewed articles in English were included for their comprehensiveness (Cunha, Meira, and Orsato 2021; Palau-Pinyana, Llach, and Bagur-Femenías 2023). We focused on the fields of “Business, Management and Accounting” and “Economics, Econometrics and Finance” due to their relevance to ESG practices (T. Li et al. 2021), resulting in an initial database of 2404 papers.

3.2 | Selection Phase

The selection phase involved defining inclusion criteria for the research articles database (Hollebeek et al. 2023). First, we selected articles from high-quality journals ranked by the ABDC, which is widely used to measure research productivity (Hirschberg and Lye 2020; T. Zhang 2022). The ABDC ranks journals in fields like economics and business on a four-point scale (A*, A, B, C) (Hirschberg and Lye 2020). Unlike the ABS list, the ABDC covers more journals and is considered more comprehensive (Paul et al. 2021; T. Zhang 2022). After removing 738 articles, 1666 papers were collected from ABDC-ranked journals.

Next, we focused on high-quality research by limiting our analysis to A*, A, and B-ranked journals from the 2022 ABDC list, excluding C-ranked papers, leaving 1365 papers for evaluation. The final selection process involved reviewing titles and abstracts for relevance to the study’s objectives (Palau-Pinyana, Llach, and Bagur-Femenías 2023; Galletta et al. 2024), focusing on ESG performance in non-financial companies (Cunha, Meira, and Orsato 2021; Fatima and Elbanna 2023).

3.3 | Inclusion Phase

By the end of the screening procedure, a total of 85 articles had been identified and used as the input for our analysis. To ascertain that all relevant articles were included in our research, the reference lists of these articles were also examined, and no other eligible articles were identified (Hollebeek et al. 2023, 2024). The data from all the selected studies are

summarized, analyzed, and presented in a detailed analysis (Galletta et al. 2024). The results of our included papers are then discussed, providing a descriptive and thematic perspective of the literature on ESG performance in non-financial companies (Fatima and Elbanna 2023).

4 | Findings

This section presents our research findings. We begin with a descriptive analysis that covers key aspects of the selected studies, including publication trends, geographical focus, and the theoretical frameworks that have been most frequently applied. This sets the stage for discussing the core dimensions of governance that influence ESG practices and outcomes. The final part addresses ESG controversies, exploring ongoing debates, and the complexities surrounding the effectiveness of ESG practices.

4.1 | Descriptive Analysis

To gain a deeper understanding of how ESG performance and disclosure are explored in non-financial firms, we cover the following key aspects.

4.1.1 | Publication Overtime

Figure 2 illustrates how the number of articles on ESG research has risen progressively through the years. Over the first period (1999–2010) of our sample, five research articles were produced, meaning that only a small part of the researchers was involved in ESG research. Over the period (2011–2020), a total of 34 articles were published, corresponding to an annual average of 3.4 articles. Consequently, this period shows an improvement, indicating the importance of ESG performance as an evolving issue, and the extent of researchers’ interest in ESG performance in relation to board composition, ownership, CEO attributes, and firm performance. Over the last 3 years, from 2021 to 2023, there have been a total of 46 research articles published, with an annual average of 15.3 publications. Such a high publication level is indicative that ESG is gaining prominence and remains a significant area of

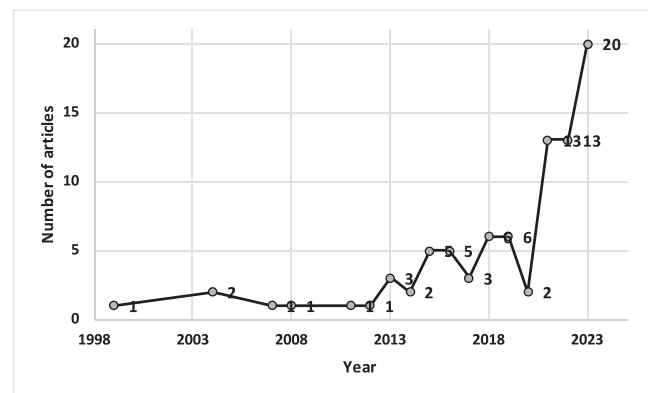


FIGURE 2 | ESG research publications over time. ESG performance articles in non-financial companies meeting sample selection criteria published annually from 2021 to 2023, following PRISMA guidelines. Source: Authors’ elaboration.

research interest for ESG performance and disclosure, in relation to corporate governance, green innovation, tax carbon, and financial performance.

4.1.2 | Articles by Journal

Table 2 summarizes 85 research studies published in 33 journals, ranked from B to A* according to the ABDC rankings. Of these, 4 journals (13%) are ranked A*, 14 (42%) are ranked A, and 15 (45%) are ranked B. Specifically, 39% of the studies are from B-ranked journals, 77% from A-ranked journals, and 6% from A*-ranked journals.

The Journal of Business Ethics (Springer) leads with 14 published studies, followed by Business Strategy and the Environment (Wiley) with 10 studies, and Finance Research Letters (Elsevier) with 9. Elsevier holds the highest number of published studies across various journals.

The four A* journals include Entrepreneurship: Theory and Practice, Journal of Accounting, Auditing and Finance, Journal of Banking and Finance, and Journal of Financial Economics, each with one study. A-ranked journals with the most articles include Journal of Business Ethics, Business Strategy and the Environment, and Finance Research Letters. Among B-ranked journals, Resources Policy, Research in International Business and Finance, and International Journal of Accounting and Information Management lead. ABS rankings indicate a mix of 4*, 4, and predominantly 2 and 3-ranked journals.

4.1.3 | Articles by Geographic Focus

Table 3 outlines the geographical distribution of ESG research across developed and developing countries. Of the 85 studies, 43 (61%) focus on 12 developed countries, and 24 (34%) on 7 developing countries, and 18 (25%) are cross-country studies.

In developed countries, the United States leads with 18 studies (26%), followed by the United Kingdom with 7 (10%). In the United States, Đặng et al. (2023) found an inverted U-shaped link between board gender diversity and environmental performance, while Bruna et al. (2021, 2022) highlighted the impact of female representation on corporate social performance. In the United Kingdom, governance impacts differ by industry, with sustainability committees and age diversity affecting governance scores (Affes and Jarboui 2023; Ozdemir and Kilincarslan 2021). Governance also affects CEO behavior in Portugal (Barros and Nunes 2007), while in Taiwan, board diversity shows an inverse U-shaped effect on firm performance (Chen and Lin 2016).

In developing countries, China leads with 17 studies (24%), followed by Thailand with 2. In China, Chen, Fan, and Song (2023) emphasized independent directors' industry-specific experience, while Farag, Meng, and Mallin (2015) linked better financial performance with lower corporate social performance disclosure. Family control enhances environmental and social

performance (X. Li, Li, and Guo 2023). In Thailand, corporate governance influences compensation but not financial performance (Detthamrong, Chancharat, and Vithessonthi 2017; Al Farooque, Buachoom, and Hoang 2019), while in Turkey, board size and family membership improve firm performance (Ciftci et al. 2019).

Panel C covers international samples, with 10 studies focusing on ESG and firm performance (Amin, Mohamed, and Hussain 2021; Harjoto, Hoepner, and Li 2020; Lahouel et al. 2021; J. Li et al. 2019), and others exploring board attributes (Lanis and Richardson 2018; A. Rehman, Gonenc, and Hermes 2023). Additional studies cover Europe (Bilyay-Erdogan, Danisman, and Demir 2023), the MENA region (Issa and Zaid 2021; Sarhan, Ntim, and Al-Najjar), and Arab markets (Omran, Bolbol, and Fatheldin 2008).

These studies provide insights on how to tailor ESG policies to regional contexts, offering valuable guidance for adapting ESG initiatives globally.

4.1.4 | Frequency and Integration of Theories

4.1.4.1 | Identification of Fundamental Theories.

Figure 3 illustrates a list of 29 theories employed in the reviewed studies to address the conceptual framework of the ESG area, representing a frequency of 126 occurrences across the 85 studies. The most frequently applied theory is agency theory, used in 26 studies, representing a percentage of 21%, followed by stakeholder theory, which was applied by 22 research papers. Legitimacy theory came next as used in 12 studies, representing a percentage of 10%. In addition, 12 other theories were used only once in the reviewed studies, such as social role theory, stewardship theory, shareholder theory, and social capital theory to explain the ESG performance or disclosure.

4.1.4.2 | Linking Theories to Existing Literature.

Most studies in the research sample use agency theory to explore the link between corporate governance and agency issues (Detthamrong, Chancharat, and Vithessonthi 2017), showing its impact on ESG performance (Đặng et al. 2023). Rossi et al. (2021) found that separating the CEO and board chairman roles enhances CSR and financial performance, while L. Nguyen (2023) showed that environmental performance can increase agency costs, reducing financial performance up to a certain point.

Stakeholder theory also plays a key role in improving ESG outcomes by addressing stakeholder demands. Effective CSR can enhance stakeholder relations and increase returns on equity (C. Nguyen, Nguyen, and Nguyen 2022), with stakeholder engagement being critical for successful ESG initiatives (Lokuwaduge and Heenetigala 2017).

Legitimacy theory explains why businesses engage in ESG. Abban and Hasan (2021) argue that companies follow

TABLE 2 | Articles by journal.

No.	Journal	No. of articles	Total %	ABDC ranking 2022	ABS ranking 2021
1	Journal of Business Ethics	14	16%	A	3
2	Business Strategy and the Environment	10	12%	A	3
3	Finance Research Letters	9	11%	A	2
4	International Business Review	7	8%	A	3
5	Resources Policy	5	6%	B	2
6	Research in International Business and Finance	4	5%	B	2
7	International Journal of Accounting and Information Management	3	4%	B	2
8	International Review of Financial Analysis	3	4%	A	3
9	Global Finance Journal	2	2%	A	2
10	International Journal of Disclosure and Governance	2	2%	B	2
11	International Journal of Finance and Economics	2	2%	B	3
12	Journal of Family Business Strategy	2	2%	B	2
13	Journal of International Financial Markets, Institutions and Money	2	2%	A	3
14	Asia Pacific Journal of Management	1	1%	A	3
15	Business Ethics	1	1%	B	2
16	Cogent Economics and Finance	1	1%	B	1
17	Ecological Economics	1	1%	A	3
18	Economic Modelling	1	1%	A	2
19	Emerging Markets Review	1	1%	A	2
20	Entrepreneurship and Regional Development	1	1%	A	3
21	Entrepreneurship: Theory and Practice	1	1%	A*	4
22	Environmental and Resource Economics	1	1%	A	3
23	International Journal of Social Economics	1	1%	B	1

(Continues)

TABLE 2 | (Continued)

No.	Journal	No. of articles	Total %	ABDC ranking 2022	ABS ranking 2021
24	International Review of Finance	1	1%	A	
25	International Review of Law and Economics	1	1%	B	2
26	Journal of Accounting, Auditing and Finance	1	1%	A*	3
27	Journal of Applied Accounting Research	1	1%	B	2
28	Journal of Banking and Finance	1	1%	A*	3
29	Journal of Business Economics and Management	1	1%	B	2
30	Journal of Financial Economics	1	1%	A*	4*
31	Journal of Risk and Financial Management	1	1%	B	
32	Pacific Accounting Review	1	1%	B	1
33	Property Management	1	1%	B	1
	Total	85	100%	—	

Source: Authors' calculation.

environmental leaders to legitimize their actions, and ESG participation can reduce risk and enhance reputation, leading to better ROA (C. Nguyen, Nguyen, and Nguyen 2022; Shakil 2021).

However, these theories have limitations. Agency theory is criticized for focusing on shareholder value and neglecting societal impacts (Jensen and Meckling 1976; Lazonick and O'Sullivan 2000). Stakeholder theory struggles with conflicting demands and lacks clarity on ESG complexities (Ghoshal 2005; Eccles et al. 2014). Legitimacy theory faces challenges with greenwashing and societal misalignment (Dowling and Pfeffer 1975; Kassem, Salama, and Ganepola 2023).

Integrating these theories could improve ESG management by addressing their respective shortcomings.

4.1.5 | Endogeneity Checks

As illustrated in Figure 4, 53 out of 85 studies performed endogeneity tests (63%), and 32 studies did not check for endogeneity issues (37%). As shown in Figure 5, the most advanced tests used for endogeneity checking are mainly instrumental variable technique (IV), 2 least squares method (2SLS), propensity score matching (PSM), and generalized method of moments (GMM).

4.2 | Core Dimensions of Governance Influencing ESG Practices and Outcomes

We next content-analyzed the literature to identify key themes in the relationship between corporate governance and ESG performance. To unpack the literature's insights, we have structured our review around several closely related themes. First, we consider the role of corporate governance structures in promoting sustainable practices and ensuring financial stability. Within this area, the board of directors' composition is a critical factor influencing how firms navigate ESG issues. The impact of ownership and management structures also comes to the fore. Further, we explore how compensation strategies can drive responsible and sustainable corporate behavior. Lastly, we turn to corporate risk management, examining how sound governance practices can mitigate risks and ensure that ESG objectives are effectively integrated into a firm's broader strategic goals.

4.2.1 | Strategic Integration of ESG Principles in Corporate Governance

Integrating corporate responsibility into governance frameworks is vital for sustainable and ethical operations (Tibiletti et al. 2020). Frias-Aceituno et al. (2013) highlight the role of boards of directors in advancing CSR and addressing stakeholder demands, making governance crucial for achieving sustainability goals.

TABLE 3 | Articles by geographic focus (developed vs. developing countries).

Panel A		
No.	Country	Nb of studies
1	United States	18
2	United Kingdom	7
3	Taiwan	5
4	Australia	4
5	France	2
6	Spain	1
7	Portugal	1
8	New Zealand	1
9	Japan	1
10	Czech Republic	1
11	Italy	1
12	Qatar	1
	Total	43
Panel B		
No.	Country	Nb of studies
1	China	17
2	Thailand	2
3	Turkey	1
4	Mexico	1
5	Ghana	1
6	Vietnam	1
7	India	1
	Total	24
Panel C		
No.	Cross-country	Nb of studies
1	International market	10
2	Europe	5
3	MENA region	2
4	Arab markets	1
	Total	18

Source: Authors' calculation.

Studies by Ting et al. (2019) and Zhang and Liu (2022) show a positive link between ESG practices and financial performance, though Tamimi and Sebastianelli (2017) note that variability was influenced by industry and scale.

Beccarello and Foggia (2023) and Dakhli (2022) advocate for sustainability-focused R&D investments to boost financial

performance, while Lokuwaduge and Heenetigala (2017) emphasize stakeholder engagement for ESG success.

Although many studies confirm the financial benefits of environmental stewardship (L. Nguyen 2023; Adomako and Tran 2022; Iwata and Okada 2011), factors like sector and scale complicate the picture. Abban and Hasan (2021) suggest a bidirectional relationship between environmental and financial performance, calling for a more nuanced view.

Overall, Table 4 shows that the literature supports ESG's financial benefits, but sector-specific impacts and external factors need further exploration. Understanding regulatory frameworks and standardized ESG disclosures is essential for enhancing sustainability in corporate governance.

We also systematically examine published research on the impact of corporate governance on financial performance globally, organized into specific subthemes (as shown in Figure 6 and Table 5): (i) Corporate Governance, (ii) Board Composition, (iii) Ownership and Management Structure, (vi) Compensation Strategies, and (v) Corporate Risk, aiming to provide a detailed analysis of governance's integral role in fostering corporate achievement and efficiency.

4.2.2 | Corporate Governance

The exploration of corporate governance and its influence on ESG performance reveals both consensus and significant variability. Amin, Mohamed, and Hussain (2021) highlight the evolving effectiveness of governance structures across a firm's life cycle, while Ciftci et al. (2019) emphasize the unique governance challenges in emerging markets, showing that governance–performance relationships must be context-specific.

Ozdemir and Kilincarslan (2021) underscore the importance of shareholder engagement and board composition in shaping ESG strategies. Affes and Jarbouli (2023) demonstrate the sectoral variability of governance impacts on financial performance, further illustrating the diverse effects of governance mechanisms.

This body of work underscores the need for adaptive governance frameworks tailored to industry and regional contexts. The complexities of governance call for further research into the factors that condition its effectiveness in promoting ESG and corporate success. The next section will examine how board diversity, particularly in gender and expertise, influences ESG strategies and overall performance.

4.2.3 | Board Composition

The exploration of board composition and its influence on ESG performance identifies three key dimensions: gender diversity, ESG expertise, and board size, each affecting ESG outcomes differently.

The literature highlights the positive impact of gender diversity on boards, particularly the role of women in enhancing social and environmental performance. Studies by Lortie, Castrogiovanni,

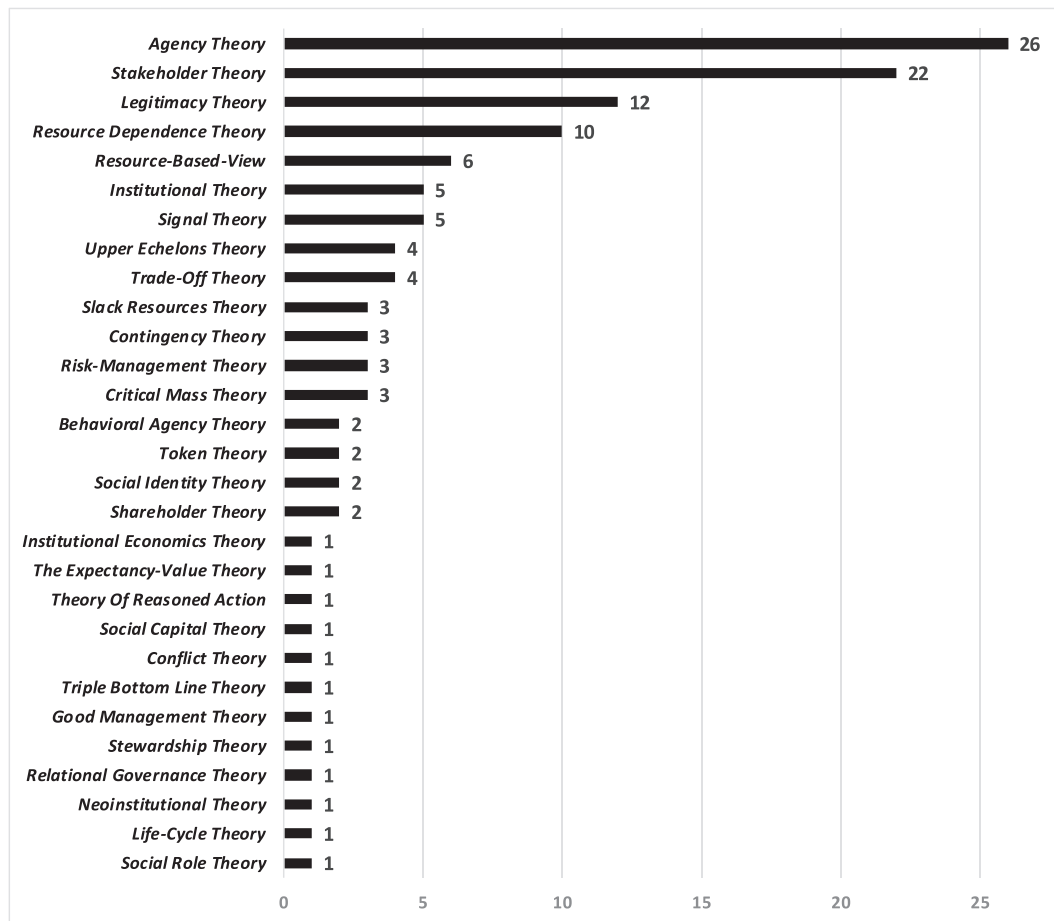


FIGURE 3 | The frequency of theories in the review articles. This figure lists the theories employed in the corpus. Since many studies employed multiple theories, the figure's total theories may not match the total reviewed studies. *Source:* Authors' calculation.

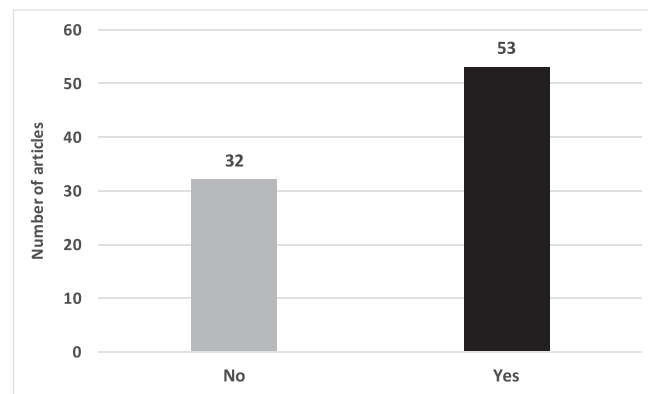


FIGURE 4 | Endogeneity check. *Source:* Authors' calculation.

and Cox (2017) and Cruz et al. (2019) demonstrate that female directors significantly improve ESG performance, bringing crucial perspectives for integrating environmental and social accountability into governance.

ESG-related expertise on boards is also essential for developing effective strategies. Boards with sustainability knowledge are better equipped to embed ESG into decision-making, as

noted by Đặng et al. (2023). However, the exact definition and impact of “expertise” require further examination.

Board size presents a complex relationship with ESG. While larger boards provide diverse perspectives, overly large boards can hinder decision-making. Research by Bruna et al. (2022) and Nerantzidis et al. (2022) suggests an optimal board size, balancing diversity and governance efficiency.

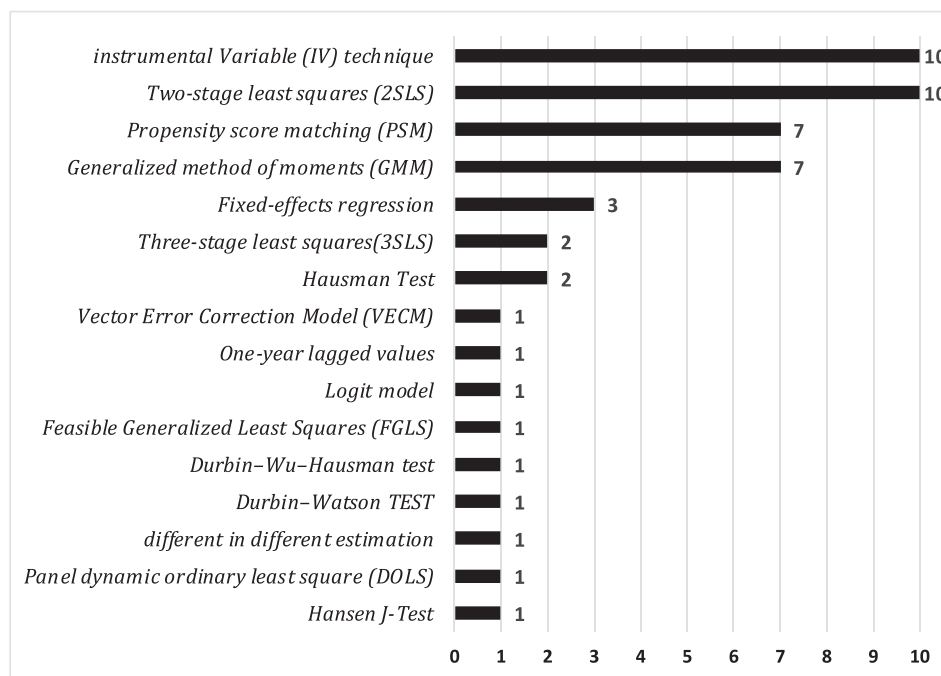


FIGURE 5 | Endogeneity tests. Source: Authors' calculation.

This review of board composition shows the importance of gender diversity, ESG expertise, and appropriate board size, emphasizing the need to consider contextual factors in shaping governance and ESG performance.

4.2.4 | Ownership and Management Structure

The relationship between ownership, management structures, and ESG performance is shaped by complex dynamics, influenced by ownership concentration, managerial autonomy, and corporate governance models. Divergent findings reveal the nuanced interplay between these factors and ESG outcomes.

Family ownership, often praised for its long-term focus, does not always enhance corporate social performance. A. Rehman, Gonenc, and Hermes (2023) note that family-owned firms may struggle with ESG in shareholder-centric contexts. Ducassy and Guyot (2017) argue that power balance between major shareholders can improve performance, suggesting that distributed ownership fosters better ESG oversight and diverse perspectives.

Board composition under family ownership also plays a key role. San Martin-Reyna and Duran-Encalada (2012) emphasize the importance of including independent directors to navigate ESG challenges, advocating for diverse boards in family-controlled firms. Peng and Yang (2014) explore the disconnect between high ownership concentration and the alignment of social and financial performance, complicating the narrative around ownership concentration's role in ESG.

These studies reveal that the impact of ownership structures on ESG performance is context-dependent, highlighting the need for

adaptive governance models suited to varying ownership configurations. Understanding these structures is essential for incentivizing leaders to meet ESG goals.

4.2.5 | Compensation

This part examines the relationship between executive compensation, corporate governance, and ESG performance, highlighting how compensation structures influence sustainability efforts. Al Farooque, Buachoom, and Hoang (2019) demonstrate the link between compensation frameworks and firm performance, while Core, Holthausen, and Larcker (1999) suggest that excessive compensation may signal governance weaknesses and poor outcomes.

Incorporating ESG criteria into executive compensation plans is crucial for guiding leadership toward sustainable practices, balancing financial and ESG goals. Increased regulatory and shareholder scrutiny has driven the need for more transparency and accountability in aligning executive pay with ESG achievements.

The findings advocate for redesigning compensation models to reward not just short-term financial success but also long-term contributions to sustainability, embedding ESG considerations into corporate leadership and governance strategies to promote responsible business practices.

4.2.6 | Corporate Risk

This synthesis of key research highlights how governance frameworks significantly shape ESG initiatives and influence financial outcomes. Shu and Tan (2023) and He et al. (2023) emphasize the role of strong governance in managing

TABLE 4 | Summary of key papers on ESG factors and their impact on financial performance.

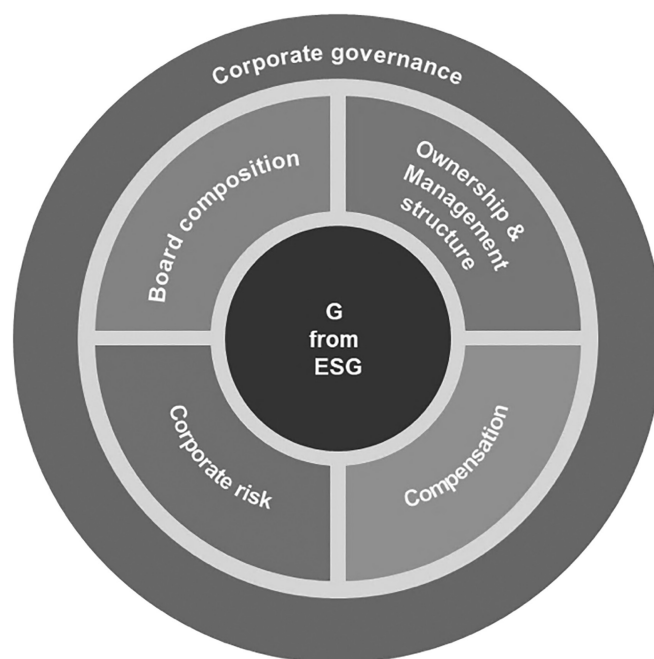
Authors (year)	Objective/research question	Main findings
Lahouel et al. (2021)	This paper aims to develop a robust method for assessing an aggregated CSP index, suitable for examining its relationship with financial performance.	- Corporate social performance (CSP) negatively impacts financial performance in the airline industry. - A negative, significant relationship exists between Tobin's Q and environmental CSR.
L. Nguyen (2023)	Investigate the correlation between environmental and financial performance, examining both linear and quadratic functions.	Enhancing environmental performance may initially reduce financial performance. However, beyond a certain threshold, further investments in environmental initiatives can lead to increased excess returns.
Dakhli (2022)	Examine the connection between corporate social responsibility (CSR) and firm financial performance, while assessing the moderating impact of audit quality on this relationship.	CSR initiatives have a positive influence on firm financial performance, assessed through metrics such as ROA, ROE, and Tobin's Q; this is more pronounced for firms undergoing audits by Big 4 auditors.
C. Nguyen, Nguyen, and Nguyen (2022)	Investigate the influence of various CSR dimensions on firm performance within an emerging context.	- CSR disclosure usually has a negative impact on financial performance. - CSR initiatives often lower return on assets (ROAs) across sectors.
Hoque (2004)	Analyze the connections between a firm's business strategy, external environment, utilization of performance evaluation measures, and organizational performance.	The study failed to identify a significant correlation between environmental uncertainty and performance concerning management's utilization of non-financial performance metrics.
Iwata and Okada (2011)	Investigate whether improved environmental performance positively impacts a firm's financial performance.	- Effective waste emission management boosts financial performance. - Lowering greenhouse gas emissions is linked to higher return on equity (ROE).
Filbeck and Gorman (2004)	Explore the relationship between environmental and financial performances within public utilities.	- Holding period returns exhibit a positive correlation with industry-adjusted environmental performance. - This relationship is more pronounced in industries characterized by an average regulatory climate.
Abban and Hasan (2021)	This study aims to elucidate the causal relationship between corporate environmental performance and financial performance (FP) within the Australian mining sector.	Findings indicate a bidirectional causality between corporate environmental performance (CEP) and financial performance (FP).
Mathew and Sivaprasad (2023)	The main aim of this study is to investigate sustainability bonds.	- Short-term market response to sustainability bond issuance is positive, signaling commitment to environmental and social causes. - ESG scores mainly influence firm performance, especially for companies issuing sustainability bonds.
Conca et al. (2020)	The study seeks to evaluate the effectiveness of ESG reporting by examining its influence on the profitability and value of listed European agri-food companies.	- Profitability is positively associated with disclosure practices focused on environmental and social information. - Company market value exhibits a negative relating to disclosure practices pertaining to governance.

(Continues)

TABLE 4 | (Continued)

Authors (year)	Objective/research question	Main findings
Meng et al. (2022)	Explore the relationship between state–business interactions and air pollution from the perspective of ESG factors.	- State–business collusion adversely impacts air quality and ESG compliance. - Clean state–business interactions contribute to lower pollutant emissions and improved ESG practices.
Atif et al. (2022)	Examine the influence of corporate ESG disclosure on cash holdings across different stages of the firm life cycle.	- ESG disclosure is negatively related to cash holdings during the introduction, growth, and shake-out/decline stages. - Lower cash holdings linked to ESG disclosure are associated with higher firm performance and a positive cash value.
Zhou et al. (2023)	This paper examines the connection between ESG performance, financial performance, and firm market value.	Improving the ESG performance of listed firms can increase the company's market value, with the firm's financial performance playing a key mediating role.

Note: The table categorizes key topics in the impact of ESG on financial performance.
Source: Authors' elaboration.

**FIGURE 6** | An illustrative framework showcasing the different subthemes within the governance pillar of ESG. Source: Authors' elaboration.

environmental regulations and mitigating corporate risk, establishing consensus on the importance of governance in improving ESG performance and financial health.

However, differences arise in the specifics. Bouslah, Kryzanowski, and M'zali (2013, 2018) link social performance to reduced risk during economic downturns, while Muhammad et al. (2015) focus on governance's role in reducing market risk through environmental strategies. Bilyay-Erdogan, Danisman, and Demir (2023) suggest that effective governance leads to favorable financial policies, including dividend payouts, while Harjoto et al. (2021) point out the economic costs of governance failures in managing social irresponsibility.

These debates underscore the complexity of applying a universal approach to the governance–ESG–financial performance relationship. The literature reveals consensus on governance's role in driving ESG, but with variations in mechanisms and contexts, highlighting the need for adaptive, industry-specific governance models.

4.2.7 | ESG Controversies

While research highlights the positive impacts of corporate governance on ESG performance and financial outcomes, it is not without debate. Aouadi and Marsat (2018) link ESG controversies to

TABLE 5 | Summary of key papers on governance subthemes and their impact on firm performance.

Authors (year)	Objective	Main findings
Detthamrong et al. (2021)	This study aims to explore the complex relationship between corporate governance and firm performance.	• Corporate governance is not correlated with financial leverage and firm performance. • Leverage positively impacts firm performance. • Audit committee size negatively impacts firm performance in large firms. • Audit reputation influences firm performance in small firms. • Financial leverage mediates the impact of audit committee size on firm performance in large firms.
Ciftci et al. (2019)	Investigate the impact of internal corporate governance mechanisms on firm performance in an emerging market.	• Ownership concentration positively correlates with firm performance. • Cross-ownership is negatively associated with firm performance. • Foreign ownership shows a positive relationship with firm performance. • Board size is positively linked with firm performance. • The proportion of family board members is positively associated with firm performance.
Ozdemir and Kilincarslan (2021)	The paper presents a multi-theoretic model to analyze the governance influence of shareholders and board of directors on firm performance.	• Industry experience of major shareholders positively influences firm performance. • Interlocking directorates of executives positively impact firm performance.
Affes and Jarboui (2023)	The study evaluates the influence of corporate governance on financial performance.	• Implementation of good corporate governance improves financial performance.
Rossi et al. (2021)	The objective of this study is to explore how board characteristics moderate the relationship between CSR practices and financial performance within ESG companies.	• CSR practices are positively correlated with higher financial performance. • CEO duality negatively moderates this relationship. • Board independence and size positively moderate the association between CSR practices and financial performance.
Akbar et al. (2016)	Investigate the correlation between corporate governance compliance and firm performance in the United Kingdom.	• Compliance with corporate governance regulations does not significantly influence corporate performance in the United Kingdom.
Wang, Qi, and Zhuang (2023)	This paper examines the influence of multiple large shareholders (MLS) on the ESG performance of Chinese listed firms.	• Firms with multiple large shareholders (MLS) exhibit lower ESG performance compared to those with a single large shareholder.
Zhao, Chen, and Xiong (2016)	The paper analyzes the relationship between managers' focus on social issues and CSP, while exploring the moderating role of corporate governance mechanisms.	• There is a positive and significant relationship between managers' attention to social issues and corporate social performance (CSP). • The relationship between attention to social issues and CSP is moderated by corporate governance mechanisms.

(Continues)

TABLE 5 | (Continued)

Authors (year)	Objective	Main findings
Đặng et al. (2023)	This paper examines the relationship between board gender diversity and environmental performance (EP).	- The study reveals an inverted U-shaped relationship between board gender diversity and EP. - Initially positive, this association becomes unclear beyond a certain threshold. - However, maintaining at least three directors from each gender appears beneficial, particularly for environmental issues.
Bruna et al. (2022)	The paper investigates the relation between the presence of women on corporate boards and corporate social performance.	The impact of women on corporate boards on corporate social performance varies based on their numerical representation.
Nerantzidis et al. (2022)	The paper examines the relationship between board gender diversity and corporate social performance.	Board gender diversity (BGD) positively influences all dimensions of CSP.
Bruna et al. (2021)	The paper examines the correlation between the representation of women on corporate boards (WOCB) and CSP.	- The results reveal a nuanced relationship: Low-CSR-performing firms experience a negative effect, possibly due to tokenism, while high-CSR-performing firms demonstrate a positive impact. - The study emphasizes a “threshold effect,” underscoring the context-specific nature of women on corporate boards’ (WOCB) influence.
Issa and Zaid (2021)	The paper investigates the interrelated connection between board gender diversity and corporate environmental performance across multiple countries in the MENA region.	The level of gender diversity on the board positively and significantly influences corporate environmental performance.
Hafsi and Turgut (2013)	The paper explores the complex relationship between boardroom diversity and corporate social performance.	- Gender and age within board diversity emerge as influential factors affecting corporate social performance. - Additionally, age diversity within boards proves to be a significant driver of CSP.
Chen, Fan, and Song (2023)	The study investigates the impact of independent directors’ human and social capital on the internationalization of firms.	- The human and social capital of independent directors positively influences firm internationalization and performance. - Independent directors’ industry-specific and international experience plays a crucial role in firm performance.
Biswas, Mansi, and Pandey (2018)	The study examines the effects of board gender composition, board independence, and the presence of a board sustainability committee on CSP of Australian firms.	Firms with increased board gender diversity, enhanced board independence, and established sustainability committees exhibit improved social and environmental performance.
Cambrea, Paolone, and Cucari (2023)	The study examines whether the presence of a critical mass of women in boardrooms correlates with firm ESG performance	Strategic placement of women directors in executive roles enhances advisory quality, positively influencing firms’ ESG performance through operational decisions rather than oversight roles.
Rehman, Gonenc, and Hermes (2023)	The study assesses the influence of shareholder protection on the CSP of family firms.	Family firms demonstrate diminished levels of corporate social performance in comparison to non-family firms.

(Continues)

TABLE 5 | (Continued)

Authors (year)	Objective	Main findings
Li, Li, and Guo (2023)	The study aims to assess the influence of corporate environmental practices on financial performance and CSP, while investigating the moderating role of family control.	- Environmental practices and financial performance show a U-shaped correlation. - Family control boosts the positive effects of environmental practices on both financial performance and corporate social performance.

Note: The table categorizes key topics in governance subthemes impact on firm performance.

Source: Authors' elaboration.

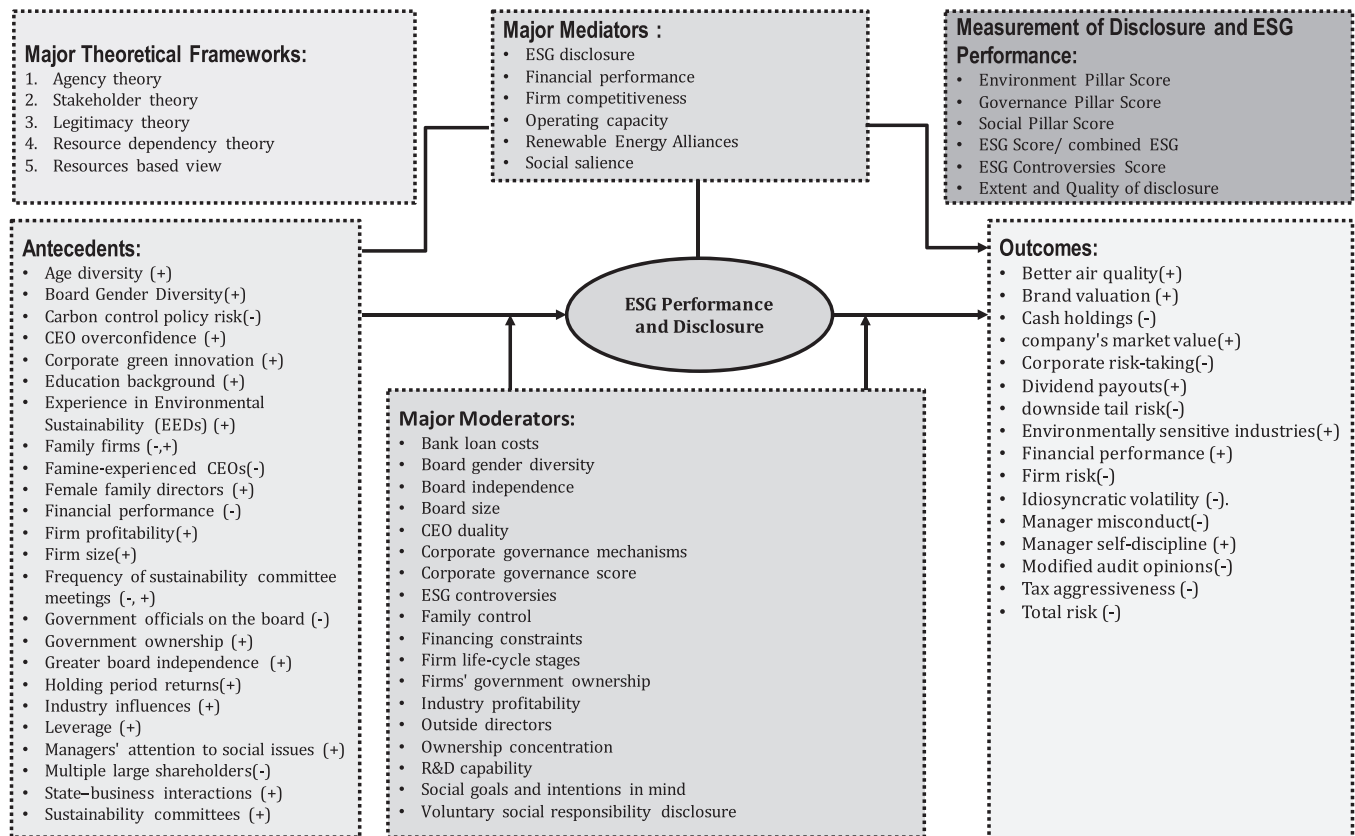


FIGURE 7 | A comprehensive model of ESG performance and disclosure. Source: Authors' elaboration.

increased market value, particularly in firms with strong corporate social performance. This suggests that effective governance can turn ESG challenges into opportunities for market value growth, emphasizing governance's crucial role in managing ESG issues.

Strong governance marked by diligent oversight and active stakeholder engagement helps firms navigate ESG controversies. Governance models that integrate ESG into their strategies offer firms resilience against controversy-induced volatilities, enhancing firm performance.

Overall, the relationship between ESG controversies and firm performance is moderated by governance quality. Strong governance not only mitigates negative impacts but also drives market revaluation, showing the importance of continuously improving governance practices. Further empirical research is needed to address the ongoing debates and inconsistencies in the literature.

5 | Conclusions

This paper offers a detailed examination of factors influencing ESG performance and disclosure in non-financial firms. The primary objective was to map the current ESG research landscape, identify gaps, and encourage further academic discussion on integrating ESG principles into corporate governance. Drawing from 85 research papers from Scopus and high-quality ABDC-listed journals, this study synthesizes key findings and emphasizes the interconnectedness of these factors.

The analysis yields three key conclusions. First, the growing body of ESG research highlights its critical role in corporate performance and disclosure. Journals like *Journal of Business Ethics* and *Business Strategy and the Environment* are highly influential. Research spans both developed (61%) and developing countries (34%), with significant transnational studies (25%).

Theories such as agency, stakeholder, and legitimacy theory frequently guide this research.

Second, a strategic alignment between CSR ethics and ESG metrics is evident, reflecting a shift toward holistic sustainability. Strong governance is shown to enhance both sustainability and financial outcomes, with high-ESG-rated firms often demonstrating better financial performance through efficient resource use and proactive risk management.

Third, emerging topics like green innovation, carbon taxes, and sustainable bonds provide new research opportunities. Future studies should explore how these variables impact ESG practices across different contexts. Based on these findings, the paper proposes an integrated framework of ESG antecedents, mediators, moderators, and outcomes.

5.1 | What This Study Adds to the Previous Systematic Review

This research adds to the existing SLR in addressing particular gaps, expanding the literature, providing rigorous methodology and bringing forward prominent theoretical, policy and managerial implications. Indeed, prior SLR reflects a fragmented comprehension of ESG, generally focusing on ESG performance and firm performance (Atz et al. 2023; Coelho, Jayantilal, and Ferreira 2023; Huang 2021; Saini et al. 2022), ESG performance drivers (Daugaard and Ding 2022; Khaw, Amran, and Teoh 2024), and ESG disclosure and firm performance (Clément, Robinot, and Trespeuch 2023; Khan 2022), without considering industry specificities, with study periods limited to 2021. Therefore, our analysis extends earlier reviews through the inclusion of papers published up to 2023, providing an added light on the developing role of ESG, using more rigorous inclusion and exclusion criteria combined with more in-depth evaluation, providing thereby a more reliable and meaningful overview. Exclusively, we systematically examine published research on the impact of corporate governance on ESG outcomes and financial performance globally, organized into specific subthemes: Corporate Governance, Board Composition, Ownership and Management Structure, Compensation Strategies, Corporate Risk and ESG controversies. In addition, these are often isolated and lack integration across the non-financial sector. This gap highlights the need for a systematic approach to fully understand the depth of ESG research in non-financial industries (see Figure 7).

5.2 | Implications

This research paper provides significant theoretical, managerial, and policy implications for the growing literature on ESG performance and its integration into corporate governance frameworks.

5.2.1 | Theoretical Implications

This study makes three key theoretical contributions. First, it systematically reviews the literature on ESG performance,

identifying research themes and summarizing objectives, and findings. This is the first attempt to create a comprehensive framework of antecedents, mediators, moderators, and outcomes of ESG performance and disclosure, filling a gap in the SLR literature based on PRISMA guidelines (Page et al. 2021). It focuses on the relationship between ESG, governance, and profitability in non-financial firms across industries.

Second, the research highlights the crucial role of corporate governance in promoting CSR and enhancing both sustainable and financial performance. It offers insights into how governance structures, board composition, ownership, and management practices influence ESG outcomes.

Third, the study identifies gaps in ESG research, urging further exploration of topics like green innovation, carbon taxes, ESG controversies, and sustainable bonds. It also calls for applying theories such as agency, stakeholder, and legitimacy in ESG research while encouraging the exploration of less-examined frameworks like relational governance, social capital, risk management, and critical mass theory (Aggarwal, Baker, and Joshi 2024).

5.2.2 | Managerial Implications

The findings offer several key implications for corporate managers. First, integrating ESG goals into corporate strategy enhances sustainability efforts and decision-making, reducing risks while creating growth opportunities (Aouadi and Marsat 2018).

Second, diverse board composition with expertise in sustainability improves ESG oversight and decision-making, essential for fostering a sustainability-driven culture. Managers must ensure boards are well-equipped to guide these efforts, especially in family-owned firms where aligning ESG with long-term vision is crucial (Nirino et al. 2021; Shu and Tan 2023).

Third, linking compensation structures to ESG performance motivates executives and employees to achieve sustainability goals, aligning personal incentives with the firm's objectives (Al Farooque, Buachoom, and Hoang 2019).

Lastly, integrating ESG risk management into the broader risk framework prepares firms to handle ESG-related challenges. Effective governance also involves managing ESG controversies through transparency and stakeholder engagement, turning challenges into opportunities (He et al. 2023; Bouslah, Kryzanowski, and M'zali 2013).

5.2.3 | Policy Implications

The study offers important implications for policymakers and regulators. First, it emphasizes the need for standardized ESG reporting frameworks that ensure comparability while accommodating industry-specific factors. Clear guidelines should be developed to balance consistency and flexibility in ESG disclosures (Ioannou and Serafeim 2021).

Second, the role of financial markets in promoting sustainable investment is crucial. Policymakers should encourage integrating ESG criteria into investment decision-making to drive sustainability through market mechanisms (Amel-Zadeh and Serafeim 2021).

Lastly, global harmonization of ESG standards is essential for cross-border cooperation and reducing regulatory inconsistencies. Policymakers should work toward aligning ESG standards across jurisdictions for more effective global sustainability efforts (Eccles and Youmans 2021).

In conclusion, the study highlights the interconnectedness of theoretical, managerial, and policy aspects of ESG, laying the groundwork for future research and practical applications in corporate governance.

5.3 | Limitations and Future Research

While this study provides a comprehensive review of ESG literature, it has some limitations. First, the focus on specific keywords and journals rated A*, A, B, and D may have excluded relevant studies from lower ranked journals, potentially limiting insights (Aggarwal, Baker, and Joshi 2024). Additionally, relying solely on the Scopus database without including others like Web of Science may have narrowed the study's scope. Future research could benefit from using multiple databases to capture a broader range of studies. Furthermore, our sample size is selected following relevant protocol, although it may be considered limited and further research may use a larger sample size to include more recent studies.

Second, concentrating on non-financial industries may limit the generalizability of findings to other sectors. Since ESG dynamics differ in financial firms, future studies should explore ESG in these sectors for a more comprehensive understanding.

Third, while key themes and gaps were identified, the study did not deeply examine complex relationships between factors influencing ESG performance. Future research should delve into governance attributes—like CEO characteristics, board diversity, and ESG committees—and their variations across ownership structures and cultural contexts (Heubeck 2023; Cambrea, Paolone, and Cucari 2023; A. Rehman, Gonenc, and Hermes 2023).

Emerging topics like ESG controversies, carbon taxes, green innovation, and sustainability bonds present promising research avenues. Future studies could explore the integration of digital transformation and green innovation and how they affect environmental performance (Chuang and Huang 2018; Lu et al. 2024). Additionally, the role of sustainability bonds in enhancing company performance needs more exploration (Mathew and Sivaprasad 2023).

From a managerial perspective, improved ESG measurement and reporting methods are critical as stakeholders demand transparency (Bain and Company 2021). Research on how digital tools like AI and blockchain can enhance ESG

performance and reporting would be valuable (Serafeim and Trinh 2021).

On the regulatory side, developing standardized ESG reporting frameworks that balance comparability with industry specificity is essential (Ioannou and Serafeim 2021). Understanding how financial markets shape ESG disclosure and fostering global harmonization of ESG standards are key areas for future research (Amel-Zadeh and Serafeim 2021; Eccles and Youmans 2021).

Overall, future research should explore the relationships between ESG factors, their contextual significance, and the development of industry-specific frameworks, guiding both companies and regulators toward sustainable growth and financial success.

Acknowledgments

We sincerely thank the two anonymous reviewers for their invaluable feedback and the editors for their indispensable ongoing support and guidance in refining this manuscript.

Conflicts of Interest

The authors declare no conflict of interest.

Data Availability Statement

Data sharing is not applicable to this article as no new data were created or analyzed in this study.

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